the state to India. When in his radio broadcast on All India Radio, on 2 November 1947, Nehru confirmed that the fate of Kashmir is ultimately to be decided by the people, and that the pledge India had signed to have a referendum would be fulfilled. Patel may well have been uneasy about the consequences of handing over political power to Abdullah, and he may have preferred an unqualified accession by the Maharaja to India. However, Nehru cast his lot with Mountbatten and Patel was overruled, India accepted the principle of the plebiscite. By giving Abdullah the plebiscite card, Nehru had institutionalised its use to prove that the Instrument of Accession was not final in itself.

It is clear that accession meant different things to different people. For Sardar Patel, accession meant that Jammu and Kashmir would become a part of India beyond all doubt, not least to guarantee the security of the northern frontier. For Nehru, accession was a means to challenge the two-nation theory by creating a secular state within the Indian Union out of a Muslim-majority province, albeit through the efforts of Sheikh Abdullah. For Mountbatten, accession, with the twist of the plebiscite, meant that the British deep state could consolidate the gains of Operation Gulmarg and execute Operation Datta Khel, thereby reinforcing the need for a plebiscite to ultimately legitimise their actions.

Sardar Patel Outmanoeuvred

For Patel, the perception of the security challenges facing post-Partition India coincided with the perception of the security challenges facing British India. There was no difference as India had inherited the mantle of power from the British Raj, notwithstanding the creation of the Dominion of Pakistan and its sequestration from the body of India. The Department of External Affairs of the Dominion of India sent a memorandum on 25 October 1947 to British Prime Minister Clement Attlee. This memorandum heavily relied upon the conceptual and strategic conclusions drawn from two other documents generated from the Indian Government that we have spoken of in the third chapter of this book. The first document, in the form